Part 2 — AI-Powered Competitive Research

Company: upGrad
Competitors: Great Learning, Simplilearn, Emeritus
Scope: Data Science & Analytics and Executive / General Management (8 programs)

Research Approach and Competitor Selection

Market research: AI-assisted desk research examined India's online higher-education and professional upskilling market, focusing on university-linked programs, career-oriented certifications, and executive education.

Competitor screening: Seven providers were considered: Great Learning, Simplilearn, Emeritus, Jaro Education, TimesPro, Scaler, and Coursera.

Selection criteria: Audience overlap with upGrad, comparable program offerings, availability of public information, and diversity of competitive positioning.

Final selection:

- Great Learning: Broad professional education and university-linked programs.
- Simplilearn: Skills-focused technical and career-oriented training.
- Emeritus: University-partnered executive education.

Research scope: Two comparable categories—Data Science & Analytics and Executive / General Management—covering eight selected programs, including upGrad.

Method: AI-assisted research of official program pages, followed by source checks, evidence audits, and identification of conflicting or unverifiable claims.

Five Key Insights

1. Data Science Programs Share Core Topics but Differ in Curriculum Emphasis

All four providers cover Python, statistics, analytics, and machine learning. However, upGrad and Great Learning offer broader data science curricula, while Simplilearn emphasizes analytics tools such as Power BI.

Why it matters: Similar program categories do not necessarily offer equivalent learning experiences.

Sources: D1, D2, D3, D4
Verification: Published curricula reviewed; actual instructional depth not independently verified.

2. Management Programs Differ in Target Audience, Duration, and Learning Format

All four providers cover finance, marketing, strategy, and leadership. However, program durations range from 6 to 12 months. upGrad primarily targets early-career professionals, while competitors serve broader experience levels.

Why it matters: Target audience, duration, and delivery format influence how directly competing programs can be compared.

Sources: M1, M2, M3, M4
Verification: Advertised durations and eligibility requirements reviewed; some delivery details are cohort-specific.

3. Inconsistent Fee Disclosures Make Direct Pricing Comparisons Difficult

For Data Science programs, upGrad advertises ₹1.80 lakh, Simplilearn ₹1.35 lakh (including taxes), and Emeritus ₹1.32 lakh + GST. Great Learning displays conflicting fees of ₹1.95 lakh + GST and ₹2.10 lakh + GST.

Why it matters: Different tax treatments, conflicting prices, and cohort-specific offers prevent reliable like-for-like pricing comparisons.

Sources: D1, D2, D3, D4
Verification: Advertised fees reviewed; final payable amounts and current-cohort applicability remain unconfirmed.

4. Institutional Partnerships Offer Different Credentials and Qualifications

All four providers emphasize partnerships or credentials associated with institutions such as IITs, IIMs, UT Austin, and Great Lakes. However, certificate types, issuing institutions, and alumni benefits differ. The selected management programs award certificates, not MBA degrees.

Why it matters: Institutional associations do not automatically imply equivalent qualifications, recognition, or learner benefits.

Sources: D1, D2, M1, M2, M3, M4
Verification: Published credential information reviewed; some certificate wording and alumni benefits require further confirmation.

5. Competitors Emphasize Different Value Propositions in Their Marketing

Official program messaging indicates different areas of emphasis:

- **upGrad:** Career advancement and university-linked credentials.
- **Great Learning:** Mentorship and career support.
- **Simplilearn:** Practical, job-relevant technical skills.
- **Emeritus:** Executive education and institutional credibility.

Why it matters: Competitors promote overlapping benefits but emphasize different aspects of their offerings to attract learners.

Sources: D1, D2, D3, M4
Verification: Based on published marketing claims and qualitative interpretation. Advertising performance and active ad counts could not be verified.

What the AI got wrong or could not verify

1. Missing source URLs

AI initially provided citation labels instead of direct URLs, making findings difficult to verify.

Correction: Requested an evidence audit and created a source register containing official URLs.

2. Historical pricing presented without sufficient context

AI-assisted research surfaced Simplilearn management pricing from an older IIM Indore cohort, creating a risk of treating historical fees as current.

Correction: Identified the historical cohort and excluded those figures from current-price comparisons.

3. Insufficient marketing evidence

AI could not reliably verify active advertisement counts. Some LinkedIn examples also lacked individual post URLs and confirmed publication dates.

Correction: Excluded unsupported advertising counts and downgraded unverifiable campaign references.

Additional observation: Great Learning's conflicting fees and upGrad's inconsistent program durations originate from their websites, not necessarily AI errors. These discrepancies were preserved and flagged rather than arbitrarily resolved.

Source Register

Data Science & Analytics

D1 — upGrad
https://www.upgrad.com/data-science-pgc-iiitb/

D2 — Great Learning
https://utaustin.mygreatlearning.com/pg-program-data-science-and-business-analytics-course

D3 — Simplilearn
https://www.simplilearn.com/iitk-professional-certificate-course-data-analytics

D4 — Emeritus
https://programs.eictiitg.com/iitg-dsba-tech-certificate-programme

Executive / General Management

M1 — upGrad
https://www.upgrad.com/iim-bangalore-general-management-certificate-for-young-leaders/

M2 — Great Learning
https://www.mygreatlearning.com/pg-program-management-executive

M3 — Simplilearn
https://iimi.simplilearn.com/executive-general-management-program

M4 — Emeritus
https://iimk.emeritus.org/iimk-general-management-programme-for-business-excellence

Additional Source — IIM Indore (Historical Cohort)
https://iimidr.ac.in/programmes/executive-programmes/long-duration-online-programmes-asynchronous/executive-certificate-programme-in-general-management-asynchronous-batch-1/

Research Date: 3 November 2026

Methodology: AI-assisted public-source research, followed by evidence audits and selected source verification. Findings reflect publicly advertised information, not independently confirmed admission offers or educational outcomes.